

GRASSLANDS AND TUNDRA

This varied biome includes tropical savannas and temperate prairies and steppes. Steppe is virtually treeless, but savanna can have an open woodland canopy. Despite their variety, grasslands are united in receiving too little rainfall to support forest but not so little that a desert forms. Rainfall may be

seasonal or spread through the year. Other factors influencing the distribution and nature of grasslands include: seasonal flooding, which prevents forest growth; geology, which heavily influences soil type and hence vegetation; and heavy grazing that has created a grassland from a former forest.

Central and South America

The Cerrado

Location Between the Pantanal, Amazon Rain Forest, and Atlantic Forest, central Brazil

This vast savanna stretches across more than 20 percent of Brazil's total area. It has a semihumid tropical climate, with a wet season and a dry season, and comprises different types of savanna crossed by closed-canopy gallery forest along watercourses. More than 10,000 species of plants, including 800 trees, have been noted here. Mammals include the giant anteater, giant armadillo, jaguar, maned wolf, and marsh deer.

▼ MORICHE PALM TREES SPREAD ACROSS THE BRAZILIAN CERRADO

Other grasslands and tundra in Central and South America

- The Pampas » pp.122-23

Africa

The Central and Eastern Miombo Woodlands

Location From southern Zambia to northern Tanzania, and from eastern Angola to northern Mozambique

Broadly divided into central Zambezi miombo woodland and eastern miombo woodland, these tropical and subtropical grasslands, savannas, and shrublands cover an area of about 745,000 square miles (1,930,000 square km). Although there are regional variations, shared features include nutrient-poor soils, the dominance of many types of miombo tree, and a long, hot dry season. Kafue National Park,

Zambia's largest protected area, and the Niassa Reserve in Mozambique are examples of these ecoregions, which have a high diversity of large mammals.

Other grasslands and tundra in Africa

- The Cape Floral Region » p.205
- Ethiopian Montane Grassland » p.204
- The Serengeti » pp.206-07
- The Sudanian Savannas » p.204

Asia

The Mongolian-Manchurian Steppe

Location Extending in a crescent north of the Gobi Desert, Mongolia to northeast China

Extensive temperate grasslands spread inland from northeastern

China's coastal hills toward the boreal forests of southern Siberia, covering almost 350,000 square miles (900,000 square km). The rolling grasslands experience warm summers and bitterly cold, windswept winters, with most rain falling in the weak summer monsoon. Feathergrasses are dominant in many areas, with drought-resistant species being more common closer to the Gobi Desert. There are also small, spiny shrubs. Native wild mammals include Mongolian gazelles and Asiatic wild asses, and Przewalski's horses have been reintroduced. The brown eared-pheasant is the only endemic bird of this ecoregion; it uses the grassland and shrub habitat as winter refuge.

Other grasslands and tundra in Asia

- The Eastern Steppe » p.260
- Siberian Tundra » p.261
- The Terai-Duar Savannas » p.260

